LESSON 1.3 | Lesson notes

Pointer Variables

Overview

A pointer is a variable that stores an address. You declare one with a star: int *p; means p can hold the address of an int. Assign it with p = ampersand x; and then p points to x. The star used on a pointer, written *p, follows the address and reads or changes the value stored there, which is called dereferencing. Writing *p = 10; changes x to 10. Always give a pointer a value before you use it; an unset pointer holds garbage and dereferencing it can crash the program.

Key points

- Part of: Memory and Addresses
- About 20 minutes
- Try the example yourself, then check it

How to use this handout

1. Read the overview first, then work through the key points in order.
2. Write down anything you are unsure about and ask in the course forum.
3. Use page 2 to plan your practice and keep notes.

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Practice checklist

- [ ] Read: Pointer Variables
- [ ] Try the example from the lesson
- [ ] Explain the main idea in your own words
- [ ] Answer the related questions
- [ ] Ask about anything unclear in the forum

My notes